

The Age of Enlightenment

From the 1650s to the 1780s, a shift in thinking occurred that became known as the Enlightenment. This period of intellectual, social and political ferment began in France, but spread rapidly across Europe and beyond. Focusing on intellectual thought and reason, it supported the advance of science and human rights, while challenging religious intolerance and corruption in Church and State. Expanded education helped the middle classes gain more autonomy. For the first time, a broader audience became interested in science, while new political ideas resulted in notions of democracy that eventually supplanted autocratic royal constitutions. Enlightenment thinkers developed new theories on education, economics, law, the workings of the universe and social and political reform.

Amid all this speculation, the taste for superficial aesthetics diminished. As many Enlightenment thinkers believed they were living in a new Renaissance, the arts of antiquity were once again considered the height of discernment.



Cochin, Frontispiece to *L'Encyclopédie*, 1772